

Story1

Daniel tossed and turned, images of Rachel flickering through his restless mind once again. The familiar scenes played out as they always did—laughing together in their first apartment, cuddling on the sofa, making pancakes on lazy Sunday mornings. More recently though, the dreams had taken on an eerie quality. The setting was invariably that strange little flat they had rented for only a few months after first moving to the city. Though they had scarcely spent any time there, its narrow rooms and cramped quarters were vivid in his nighttime wanderings. But the flat felt somehow frozen in time, locked away and abandoned, holding memories that refused to release their grip on him.

They were young and foolish, rushing into marriage without fully appreciating how much they still had to learn about life and about themselves. The flat represents a kind of turning point - the start of realizing how different they were, how incompatible in so many ways. When they first moved to the city, they were blinded by the thrill of independence and the possibilities of the future. Rachel had always loved the vibrancy and culture of city life, while Daniel had grown up in a small rural town and was in awe of bustling city streets. The sounds of traffic and sirens outside their window had seemed exciting rather than annoying at first.

But soon disagreements arose, about everything from finances to lifestyle choices. Rachel dreamed of becoming an artist and embracing a bohemian lifestyle, while Daniel was drawn to more stable pursuits. Daniel had always been pragmatic and careful with money, whereas Rachel was more spontaneous and free-spirited. She would make impulsive purchases and go into debt, causing many arguments that chipped away at their early happiness. Their fights grew in intensity and frequency, and they both said hurtful things which they later regretted.

Their young love was passionate but turbulent, ranging from blissful highs to bitter confrontations. Still, a part of him clung to the memories of how happy they once were in that little flat, hoping to recapture the magic of those early days. However, after frequent cycles of arguing and making up, the incompatibilities they had tried to ignore could no longer be avoided. The veneer of new romance faded, and reality set in. By then Daniel realized how truly different they were, and how unlikely to find common ground or lasting happiness together. Daniel remembered one argument where Rachel had thrown a vase at him in anger, shattering it against the wall. He flinched at the memory of glass fragments littering the floor. There were better times too of course, early on Rachel snuggling in his arms during a thunderstorm, feeding each other leftover cake and giggling. Those memories only made their later fights more painful.

He woke with a start in the early hours of the morning, his heart pounding, the memories of Rachel refusing to release their hold on his slumbering mind. In the dim light he could make out Isabel's sleeping form beside him. A pang of guilt shot through him. His kind, patient girlfriend deserved better than for him to still be troubled by a failed marriage from years ago. He reached

out and gently stroked her hair, taking solace in her familiar warmth and the slow, steady rhythm of her breathing. Her soft curls slid through his fingers, grounding him in the present and chasing away the last stubborn remnants of the dreams. Still, he knew the peace would be temporary until he found a way to confront the memories still holding him captive all these years later.

Over coffee later that morning, Daniel decided to confide in Isabel about the dreams that had been disturbing his sleep. Though usually reticent when it came to talking about his past relationship, he felt she deserved an explanation for his recent restlessness. Isabel listened thoughtfully as Daniel recounted the details of the strange recurring dreams and his unsettling feeling of being trapped in that forgotten flat. Her hand reached for his as he struggled to find the right words to express the tumult of emotions these visions had awakened in him. He felt a rush of gratitude for her kindness and patience. Though they had only been dating six months, he was beginning to imagine a future with this caring, compassionate woman by his side.

"It sounds like your subconscious is trying to work through some lingering feelings about that time, she said gently. "Maybe there are still some loose ends you need to tie up about the end of your marriage, even after all these years. Daniel contemplated this as he gazed out the kitchen window, watching a pair of squirrels chase each other around the bare winter trees in his garden."You could be right, he said slowly. He began recounting many more details about their relationship and time in that flat to Isabel. How they had spent hours exploring the neighborhood around their new home when they first moved in, discovering little cafes, bookshops and parks together. The evenings they stayed up late talking, open hearted and optimistic that love would solve any challenges they might face. Isabel listened patiently and squeezed his hand, giving him the courage to continue opening up about memories he had long kept locked away. Rachel had seemed like a free spirit when they met, her smile bright as the sun. They would go on adventures in the city, searching for hidden treasures in thrift stores and trying out different ethnic restaurants. For a while, life with her was thrilling and unpredictable. The flat represented such an exciting new beginning for them, finally living together in their own space.

"Why don't you try and find the old flat? We could even go visit the place. It might help to confront it in person and hopefully release its hold on you.

Daniel smiled gratefully at her. "That's a wonderful idea. Thank you, my dear, for always knowing the right thing to do." A week later, keys in hand, they made their way to the old neighborhood. The familiar street looked shabbier than Daniel remembered, old shops now boarded up or replaced. But when they arrived at the flat everything was just as he had dreamed it, as though untouched by the years. As he crossed the threshold into the musty rooms he was awash in recollection, flooded by a bittersweet nostalgia for early days gone by. His hands caressed the familiar surfaces and edges as a cascade of memories flowed through his mind, transporting him back in time. The spattering yellow linoleum, unchanged and uncared for all these years, brought recollections of

weekend breakfasts and laughter-filled evenings. The cheap flatpack furniture they had excitedly bought together now looked worn and dilapidated. The sagging green sofa where they had cuddled in front of the TV during rainy Sundays, sharing whispered jokes and sweet kisses. He remembered their worst fight in this flat, how Rachel had thrown her ring at him in anger, the metal band skittering across the floor. And how they had later wept in each other's arms, desperate to find a way to fix the cracks in the fragile foundation of their marriage.

Isabel slipped her arm through his and together they explored each space, awakening memories that no longer stung as before. By the time they left, the flat felt at peace in Daniel's mind. Its doors were closing for good, releasing him to fully embrace the life and love still ahead.

They stopped for coffee at the little cafe down the street, the same cafe where he and Rachel had spent hours in the early days of their relationship, lost in conversation and feeling as though they had all the time in the world to learn each other's hearts. How poignant to sit here with Isabel now, while the late afternoon sun streamed in the windows. The past felt distant and hazy, no longer threatening to reach out its grasping fingers and pull him back. Daniel gazed at Isabel, glowing in the golden light, and felt a surge of certainty that their story was only just beginning. The future unfolded before them, full of promise and new memories waiting to be made together each day.

-----The End-----

Story2

Daniel had started having recurring dreams again. They persisted through weeks, like a fire burning slowly through damp straw. He had the feeling that each dream was held in a room of his mind, and the rooms were dark and cloudy, with shadows fluttering on the edges of the walls, invisible and frightening. With this, there was an idea—an obsession that had been working inside him. He wondered if his dreams were not being held in his mind, but in the unused flat their landlord Mr. Dunlop insisted lay below them, beneath the worn sandstone steps in the wide, dimly lit hallway. Daniel had never entered nor seen the flat, and yet it had taken on a sinister fascination since the dreams began. They were dreams of his ex-wife, Rachel, and of events he could not place in his memory. Dreams that left him shivering and weak, like the cold aftermath of an attic fire.

He did not often speak of them to Isabel except by accident. One day, sitting at a quiet bar around noon as the shadows from the windows painted stripes across the tables, Daniel let a fragment slip.

"I keep seeing that old flat—It's a dream I have," he said, his eyes searching her face frantically, "of that flat, and it frightens me."

"Which flat?" Isabel asked tenderly.

"The one beneath ours."

"What happens?"

"Nothing much," he replied. "I suppose I left something there."

"You've never been there before?"

"Never."

"Do you want to visit it?"

"No. I don't know."

She sat still, waiting, watching his tense and delicate gestures. He dove into his club soda miserably, knowing that he could say nothing to her that she would not receive tenderly. Yet they both understood; he was reserved, and he wanted, moreover, to protect her from the darkness he found lurking inside himself.

"Come on," she said suddenly, throwing a ten-dollar bill on the table, her long, auburn hair flicking past her effervescent eyes. "Let's hunt for treasures in those rooms."

The air had been drained of all freshness as they left the bar and began the ascent. How many times had they walked this dim hallway, and how many times in his dreams had he done it alone, seeing Rachel appear from behind the warped brown door which led to the basement flat, a door that always seemed to be waiting and silent when he passed it.

Hand on the door, he hesitated. He knew he was half-drunk, and he felt vulnerable, weak with the weight of the silence and the dark hallway behind him. He did not want to open the door, and he knew he was afraid. Yet Isabel, sensitive and perceptive as ever, turned the doorknob, and as the door swung inward, they shared an uneasy feeling that there was a mingling of dreams and wishes flowing from the door.

Isabel stepped forward into the room, her gaze scanning over the old, sparsely furnished flat. Her eyes caught on a dull bronze key, hanging on a peg on the wall adjacent to the door.

"Do you think that key fits something down here?" She asked, her curiosity taking hold.

"I wouldn't dare to find out," Daniel replied solemnly, his eyes distant, cast down at the worn rug beneath his feet.

And at that moment, they left. Isabel took the key and slipped it into her pocket, and they locked the door behind them. They never spoke of it again, as if laying to rest a dream that had no place in their waking lives.

The days that followed passed calmly enough and seemed to put distance between Daniel and his dreams. One night, fueled by a few glasses of wine, they began to speak of their past relationships. They had been together a few years,

yet there was always some nugget of the past they had held back, a memory that they were too afraid—or too ashamed—to offer the other.

"Why did you stop seeing Gracie?" Daniel asked suddenly.

"She had me hidden. We'd been dating for a while, but I never met any of her friends, her parents—"

"Our childhoods shape us," she added hastily. "I've grown since then."

"Why did you and Rachel divorce?" Isabel asked, staring at the candle flickering between them.

"Like water and oil, we," he said, groping for words, "we separated. It had been years since I could remember pursuing her, really trying to win her love. We were side by side, yes, but there was no way to bridge the distance."

Daniel leaned back in his chair, closing his eyes as he searched his heart. "Nothing ever made me feel like I had that love from her," he said quietly, a hint of sadness lingering in his voice.

"There's beauty in that honesty," she whispered, placing her hand on his.

For days, Daniel thought of their pasts: his divorce from Rachel, Isabel's separation from Gracie, and the honesty they'd shared that night. There had been no cruelty in their former lives, no viciousness beyond the everyday struggles that grated and bent. Daniel wondered if he was not destroying something with his memories and his dreams, and if he was not letting them fall against the protective fences he had built around Isabel's and his own heart. Their shared pasts hung in the darkness around them, like shadows in a firelit room. And Daniel wondered if that was what he had wanted, to share his darkness.

He had been drifting through his day, the bronze key he had found in the flat weighing heavily in his pocket. The bland faces and sluggish voices of his coworkers seemed like half-faded memories, as if only half-present. Daniel drew the key out of his pocket, feeling its cold surface, which emitted a strange sad energy, an echo of the past.

And then, a vivid, yet disconnected memory washed over him – the image of Rachel, gliding silently in a canoe, her hair dancing in the breeze. He saw her vividly, as if they were together in that moment. The water lapping at the canoe, the air crisp and light – it had been their favorite pastime, now lost to time.

As the day waned into evening, Daniel nearly floated home, the memory of the paddled canoe shining like a beacon in the darkness of past recollections. He told Isabel of the memory as soon as he saw her, eager to share something brighter from his past, and perhaps make it a part of their present.

"That's such a nice memory, Dan," she said softly.

"It's been a while since we've done something like that. Maybe we can go canoeing this weekend?" he suggested, an earnest excitement in his eyes.

Smiling, Isabel agreed, her eyes lighting up with anticipation.

The days seemed to soften as they approached the weekend. Quiet laughter and gentle warmth mixed amidst their shared space, and as they set out on the river in their rented canoe, it seemed as if the tangible gloom which had beset Daniel for weeks had finally evaporated. The sun danced on the water and their love for one another was palpable, as if the universe itself recognized their bond.

That evening, as they lay in bed together, Daniel held Isabel close, overcome with gratitude for the love they shared. The key glinted from where it now lay on the dresser, now a token of the past Daniel had made peace with.

The dreams of the unused flat and Rachel had gone, like fleeting whispers in the wind. And Daniel knew he'd finally found his way to reconnect—to reconcile his past memories and his present relationship. The dreams had retreated to the darkest corners of his heart, leaving him with a newfound sense of wholeness and peace.

-----The End-----

Story3

Daniel sat up in bed, sweat clinging to his brow. Yet again, he had fallen victim to the relentless clutches of the past. The vivid dreams of his ex-wife Rachel had become hauntingly routine, leaving him in a state of confusion and yearning for closure. But now, a new element had seeped into the depths of his subconscious—a strange, unused flat that seemed to hold a key to his unresolved emotions.

Unable to contain his inner turmoil any longer, Daniel confided in his current partner, Isabel, about the dreams that haunted him. Over cups of steaming coffee, they sat facing each other in their sunlit kitchen, the morning rays casting a glow on their faces.

"I don't understand why these dreams keep happening," Daniel confessed, frustration lacing his voice. "They're like echoes from a life I thought I had moved on from."

Isabel reached out and squeezed his hand gently, her eyes full of understanding. "Sometimes, our past has a way of finding us, even in our dreams," she murmured.

Together, they delved into their intertwined histories, peeling back the layers of their past relationships, and dissecting the remnants left behind. Conversations spiraled into deep reflections, uncovering wounds that had perhaps never fully healed.

Days turned to weeks, and Daniel's dreams continued to weave an ethereal tapestry of nostalgia and regret. Until one day, as he rummaged through a dusty drawer, his eyes landed on a forgotten set of keys. The mere sight of them ignited a long-forgotten memory—a canoe in the backyard of a house he had lived in many years ago.

Heart pounding with curiosity, Daniel reached out for Isabel's hand and led her towards the old house, long since abandoned. The creaking floorboards beneath their feet seemed to echo the untold stories of past residents, lingering in the air like whispers.

As they approached the backyard, Daniel's eyes fell upon the weathered canoe, half-buried in a bed of wildflowers. Brushing away the layers of dust, memories surged forth like rapids, carrying him back to a time when the simplicity of life was encapsulated in the rhythmic strokes of paddles against water.

"Isabel," Daniel whispered, his voice choked with nostalgia, "do you remember how much we used to love canoeing?"

A faint smile graced Isabel's lips as she too became engulfed in the memories. "Of course, I do," she replied softly. "Those were the moments when the world faded away, and it was just the two of us, floating on calm waters."

In that moment, an idea blossomed between them. They would reconnect with each other, finding solace in the familiar serenity of the tempestuous current. The canoe would become a vessel not only for traversing the physical waters but also for navigating the turbulent depths of their emotions.

As the sun dipped below the horizon, casting a kaleidoscope of colors across the sky, Daniel and Isabel set the canoe afloat on a nearby lake. With each stroke of the paddle, their laughter mingled with the soft lapping of water, melting away the barriers between past and present.

In the coming weeks, the couple would embark on countless canoeing adventures, exploring new lakes and rediscovering forgotten parts of themselves. The familiar joy and tranquility they had once shared found its way into their present relationship, inching them closer to a future built on shared experiences and mutual growth.

The dreams of Rachel still lingered in Daniel's periphery, but they no longer held the power to consume him. With each paddle stroke, he found himself letting go of the past, embracing the beauty of the present, and eagerly anticipating the vastness of the future.

That night, as Daniel and Isabel lay entwined beneath a starlit sky, he finally realized that sometimes, our dreams serve as catalysts for finding our way back to where we truly belong—bringing us closer to the present, and into the arms of the person who holds our heart.

Months rolled by, and Daniel and Isabel continued their canoeing adventures, exploring new lakes and waterways amidst the changing seasons. Each journey

brought them closer to nature and to each other, providing a respite from the fast-paced world they lived in.

Daniel had always possessed a deep appreciation for the intricate details of the natural world, and as he and Isabel paddled along calm rivers and vibrant lakes, he couldn't help but feel a renewed sense of wonder. The beauty of the surroundings mirrored the beauty he found in Isabel, and he realized how lucky he was to have her by his side.

One sunny morning, they decided to venture into a secluded river that wound its way through a dense forest. The air was alive with the melody of chirping birds and rustling leaves. The water flowed serenely, mirroring the vibrant greens above. It was as though they had stumbled upon a hidden sanctuary, far removed from the worries of everyday life.

As they floated down the river, Daniel's mind wandered to memories of his childhood. He used to visit his grandparents' farm and spend hours exploring the nearby streams, feeling a deep connection to the flowing water. Canoeing had always been a part of his life, offering solace and adventure.

Lost in his thoughts, Daniel's paddle rhythmically dipped in and out of the water, guiding them effortlessly along the meandering river. The time seemed to stand still as they embraced the tranquil beauty that enveloped them.

Eventually, the river led them to a small clearing, bathed in dappled sunlight. They decided to take a break and rest on the riverbank, the canoe nestled against the soft grass. As they sat there, hand in hand, they listened to the whispering breeze and watched as dragonflies danced on the water's surface.

In that moment, Daniel realized that it wasn't just about the destination or the physical act of canoeing. It was about the journey itself—the exploration of inner and outer landscapes, the connection forged with nature and the person he loved.

As the afternoon waned, Daniel and Isabel reluctantly rose from their peaceful perch and resumed their journey back home. The voyage had left an indelible mark on their souls, igniting a profound sense of gratitude and a renewed commitment to living life to the fullest.

From that day forward, Daniel and Isabel continued their canoeing adventures with a zest for life and an unwavering love for one another. Each time they set foot in a canoe, they discovered something new about themselves and the world around them.

The dreams of Rachel gradually faded, becoming distant memories that no longer held power over Daniel's heart. He had found solace and closure in the never-ending flow of water, in the gentle glide of the canoe, and in the warmth of Isabel's hand in his.

As they paddled into the horizon, beneath a sky painted with orange and gold hues, Daniel realized that the dreams that had haunted him for so long had led

him here—to a place of healing, growth, and most importantly, love. And he couldn't be more grateful for the journey, the memories, and the person beside him.

With each new adventure, their love story unfolded, weaving a tapestry of resilience, forgiveness, and the profound beauty of second chances. Together, Daniel and Isabel navigated the rivers of life, exploring uncharted waters that brought them closer to themselves and each other.

As the years went by, canoeing became not just a hobby, but an anchor in their relationship—a reminder of the strength they had found in vulnerability and the comfort they discovered in the embrace of nature. Through the highs and lows, they faced life's challenges with unwavering determination, drawing strength from the beautiful memories they had created on their canoeing expeditions.

They paddled through crystal-clear lakes, their laughter ringing through the serene surroundings. They ventured into raging rivers, conquering the tumultuous rapids as a team. And they floated along peaceful streams, savoring the quiet moments of connection and introspection.

Daniel and Isabel's love story blossomed and grew with every stroke of the paddle and every whisper of the wind. Their bond, forged amidst the timeless beauty of nature, became unbreakable—an unbreakable thread woven into the very fabric of their souls.

Together, they explored remote lakes, capturing the essence of untouched landscapes through their shared experiences. They marveled at the breathtaking sunsets and painted dawn skies, immersing themselves in the sheer wonder of nature's palette.

As they glided along the shimmering waters, Daniel and Isabel discovered a newfound appreciation for the fleeting moments and the deep-rooted connections that made life meaningful. They learned to find joy in simplicity, to cherish the quiet moments, and to hold gratitude for the gift of each new day.

With every journey, their love became stronger, their relationship more resilient. They faced life's storms with the same bravery and unwavering spirit they displayed on their canoeing expeditions, drawing on the lessons learned from the rivers that had shaped them.

In the end, it wasn't just about the memories created on their canoeing adventures, but the lessons they carried with them—a reminder to embrace the unknown, to trust in the journey, and to always paddle forward, hand in hand.

As the sun set on their golden years, Daniel and Isabel looked back on the tapestry of their lives, colored by the vibrant strokes of their shared adventures. They saw a life well-lived, a love story that unfolded across lakes and rivers, and a legacy of resilience, passion, and unyielding love.

Their canoe had carried them through the winding paths of life, guiding them through the rapids and calm waters alike. And as they gently put their paddles

to rest, they knew that their love would forever navigate the streams of their hearts—flowing, constant, and brimming with the beautiful memories of a life well-canoeed.

-----The End-----

Story4

Years after leaving his wife and taking up with Isabel, Daniel would dream that he was back home, with Rachel. They were together again. Isabel had left him, or he had never really left Rachel. Or somehow both. He felt reassured, but also extremely anxious, like a man emerging from a coma, uncertain whether he is alive or dead.

Always, in these dreams, his thoughts would go to a bunch of keys. Somewhere, in a bag or a jacket pocket, there was a tangle of old keys. The keys to a small flat, he thought. A place whose rent he had been paying for years, without actually using it. A place where he could be alone, without Rachel or Isabel. Or where he could invite Isabel, without Rachel. But, for some reason, it was impossible for him to look for those keys on their shabby leather loop. It was impossible to do anything at all.

In some variations, he tried to phone Isabel, to ask why she was no longer in touch, but the screen wouldn't respond to his fingers. Strange symbols appeared that he could not interpret.

Then he would wake up with Isabel beside him, sleeping soundly. He felt immensely relieved and happy.

But one night Daniel's dream took another turn. This time he woke from another dream and found not Isabel but Rachel beside him; all had been made up between them and they were together in placid old age. At once he was looking for his phone to call Isabel. How had things ended between them? And where were the missing keys? It was crazy paying rent for a place you never used.

Then he woke properly, beside Isabel, but shaken. This time he told her about his dream. She pondered. Perhaps, she said, in a part of yourself, you wish you were back with Rachel.

Not at all!

I'm not accusing you, Dan.

He wished he hadn't said anything and decided to steer clear of the subject. But, some days later, Isabel asked, What's Rachel like, in these dreams of yours?

Daniel sighed.

Just curious, she added. Dreams are so vague, he said.

A month later, it came again. Afterward, Daniel lay awake, as if he had been assigned a puzzle to solve. He and Rachel had been in an expensive house where

there was a large, airy room that for some reason they never used. Water was streaming down the walls and gathering in a pool on the floor. Rachel was a hazy figure in a white nightdress. It seemed they had just made love.

What was Rachel like in these dreams? Daniel remembered Isabel's question and cast about for an answer. She had been busy, sorting out a cupboard full of dish towels. And there was something sad about her, but resilient, as if she had survived a serious illness. Sarcastic, too. She found him ridiculous, like a little boy playing truant. Her accusation turned his mind to the keys. They would be in one of those places where you stored things that you weren't immediately using. A kitchen drawer, a garage shelf. The main fact about Rachel, though, was simply that she was Rachel. His ex-wife. Daniel lifted himself on an elbow to watch Isabel sleeping. Calm and snug.

Daniel and Isabel enjoyed going for long walks in the country. The following weekend, they stopped at a pub and took beers outside to a splintery table.

Isabel mentioned that her ex had been in touch recently. Geoff. He had sent her a link to some political article he thought might interest her. Sounding off about corruption. Did you reply?

A line or two. To be friendly. But I never dream about being back with him.

It's not that I want to have these dreams, Daniel said.

You always imagine I'm accusing you! After all, she added, it makes sense—you were with Rachel for twenty years. I only knew Geoff for two.

They finished their beers and set off home. But the conversation was well and truly started now; it would have to be taken somewhere.

The problem is, Daniel said, that we're talking as if dreams had meaning.

If they were completely random, why would you go on having the same one?

I have plenty of other dreams.

But you don't fuss over them.

Daniel said maybe the problem, deep down, was that he was afraid that Isabel would leave him; she was so much younger. Isabel protested that she never would. Then asked, But supposing I did, would you go back to Rachel?

Of course not!

And so?

Alone, Daniel wondered about the phantom flat that always came to mind in these dreams, the place the keys would open. He had a vague impression of a semi-basement bedsit in the eastern suburbs of the city. The kind of place where a wounded animal might go to hide. He had looked at any number of flats after leaving Rachel, and they had all seemed dusty and melancholy.

Sometimes I wonder if it isn't physiological, he told Isabel. There are these old experiences, half dissolved, you know, clogging up some mental drain. We need to pour some Mr. Muscle down there.

Isabel laughed, but, when her friend Hilary came to dinner, a few days later, she poured prosecco and said, Dan has been dreaming of being back with his ex. Uh-oh! Hilary said, laughing. Time for the analyst!

Daniel was unsettled by this disclosure, which he hadn't expected. He had long since signed off with his analyst, he said, and had no desire to go back. I'm a perfectly happy man, he declared.

So why did you mention it? I wish I hadn't.

Isabel raised her eyes across the table. No, you did the right thing, Dan. I wouldn't want you worrying about something and not talking to me about it. Perhaps you needed a problem, Hilary proposed. You're too happy. That sounds about right, Daniel agreed.

But the dream came again. He and Rachel were in a beautiful room, full of light, except there was a pond on the floor between the sofa and the piano. Rachel was knitting at the dining table. He had nothing to do and was staring into the water of the pond, which was choked with bright-green weeds. Tiny insects flitted across the surface. Then very distinctly Rachel said, If you want, you can invite her to dinner. Invite who? he asked. Who do you think? she said, laughing. Your latest squeeze. Daniel was dumbfounded. What do I care what you do? Rachel added. You'd never have the courage to leave me.

Waking in a sweat, Daniel decided to say nothing about this. "Squeeze was offensive, and these dreams had caused enough trouble already. Later that week, though, Isabel hit a curb and had a flat tire. Pulling the spare from the boot, Daniel found, beneath it, a bunch of keys on a black leather loop. They were the keys to the canoe club, near his old home—a key for the outside gate, a key for his locker, and another for the paddle rack. How I loved canoeing, he thought.

For the first time, Daniel stopped thinking about his dreams and cast his mind directly to the past. It had been seven years now since he and Rachel had split up, and he realized that he couldn't quite recall how or why it had all come to a head. He hadn't known Isabel then. Of course, there had been any number of quarrels and betrayals, but none of them seemed to explain why he had walked out when he did. The past is a dream, Daniel thought. There is no way to make sense of it. He did remember, though, that, the summer before the marriage ended, in an attempt to save things, he had invited Rachel to go canoeing with him. And they had gone twice, on the lake, which was easier than the river. Those outings had seemed promising. They'd had a good time. But then she'd refused to go anymore. You're good at canoeing, she explained. I'm not.

Daniel thought about this for a whole week. Spring was coming, and these were the first mild days.

What about going canoeing, next weekend? he proposed to Isabel. Weather permitting. We could take a picnic.

Great idea, she said. She frowned. You'll have to teach me how, though.

No problem, he said. It's not that hard.

After a little reflection, he tossed the old keys in the recycling. But he kept the shabby leather loop, for old times' sake.

-----The End-----